

New features

Lucid Lynx has introduced many new and improved features in this release. One of them is the cloud and social networking integration. Ubuntu One lets you seamlessly sync chosen data to Canonical servers. What sets this offering apart from other existing cloud storage options is the ability to sync notes from Tomboy, bookmarks from Firefox (you need to install a Firefox plug-in) and contacts from Evolution, in addition to data files. The free account provides you with 2 GB of storage space, and you can later buy more. Figure 1 shows the synchronisation options dialogue for the Ubuntu One service.

Lucid has also integrated the Ubuntu One Music Store (UOMS) into Rhythmbox—see Figure 2. Banshee has introduced an Ubuntu One music plug-in that does the same. The offerings aren't that diverse—I didn't find any tracks that I'd want to buy, only alien tracks and artists that I have never heard of. Ubuntu One offers you a small audio preview before purchasing the album/track. Though it has some nice features, UOMS has shortcomings as well. For starters, all songs you download go into the Ubuntu One folder and will be synced automatically; once you reach the 2 GB limit, you are restricted from further downloads and have to either pay to increase your Ubuntu One storage space, or move media files out of your Ubuntu One folder. Even though UOMS offers DRM-free media in association with 7digital, a European music distributor, you're still forced to install the proprietary MP3 codec, without which you cannot even browse the music store. Not great for people who believe in freedom in their software!

The huge social networking trend is reflected in Lucid's tight integration of Empathy for chat (supports most popular IM services) and Gwibber (supports Facebook, Twitter, identi.ca and other social networking sites) into the Messaging menu (Figure 3). You can access the menu from the Mail icon in the system tray. The Messaging tray has quite a few features—it categorises similar applications and reduces the clutter in the System tray, and also allows you to launch an application from it. In Ubuntu 9.10, the Mail icon changed to a dull colour on receipt of a message; in 10.04, it turns to a more visible green. But I still miss a lot of messages from friends while working, because it's too unobtrusive even now.

Gwibber is still buggy, though: I noticed that the client was not showing time-lines and replies from my Twitter and Facebook accounts, though if I posted an update it showed up on the respective website. After spending time searching for a solution, I ended up giving up on Gwibber, and am currently using Pino.

The Me menu (Figure 4) provides a central location for managing all your online (social and chat) accounts, as well as Ubuntu One settings. This chat and social network integration is intended to let you broadcast status updates to all configured accounts, monitor IM and other accounts for new messages, and directly launch the relevant application. However, this only works if you have Gwibber up and running pretty quick. The Me menu also lets you change your status for IM chat sessions.

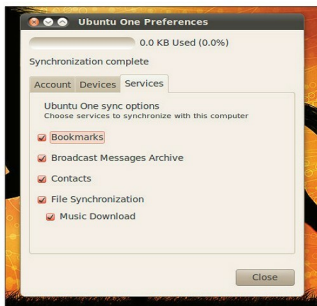


Figure 1: Ubuntu One synchronisation options



Figure 2: Ubuntu One music store home page

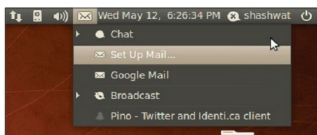


Figure 3: Messaging menu

Ubuntu has also revamped the notification system, with more compact and better-looking notifications (Figure 5).

Software and applications

Lucid carries Linux kernel 2.6.32, GNOME 2.30.0, Firefox 3.6.3, Open Office 3.2 and X Server 1.7—new software, and it works amazingly well! The inclusion of X Server 1.7, and AMD's lag in releasing an updated proprietary driver made me hesitate to use Ubuntu as my primary OS, but not only did AMD deliver a new version for Lucid, Ubuntu stunned me with compositing working out of the box with open-source drivers on my desktop, and a couple of the laptops. This last